not to join issue since any elaboration would have seemed defensive and unconvincing. Time alone should establish my credibility.

The press conference lasted an hour, longer than the typical thirty–forty-five minutes of post-policy conferences under my predecessor, Governor Reddy. It seemed a success on several fronts. The explanation of the rationale for the slew of crisis-response measures gave the media an appreciation of the context in which we were operating; the media got a full, good look at me, enough to size up the new governor; and at a personal level for me, it drove away the fear of the unknown. Most importantly, it set the tone for a very constructive and happy relationship that I enjoyed with the media through my five-year term.

The criticism that I was ceding control of the Reserve Bank's crisis response to the government was weighing on my mind, but as I said, there was nothing much I could do to reverse what I thought was an ill-informed view. Time alone would have to neutralize that.

My bigger concern though was whether I was, even at this very beginning of my tenure, losing credibility with my own staff in the Reserve Bank. What if they too became prejudiced by all the talk of my inability or unwillingness to protect the Reserve Bank's turf? Instead of looking up to me for my professional competence and intellectual integrity, they would be looking at me with suspicion, and worse, distrust. This would hurt my reputation in many ways, but even more importantly, it would compromise my effectiveness, something that the Reserve Bank could not afford, least of all in a crisis situation like this.

Hopping from job to job and organization to organization is standard fare in an IAS officer's career trajectory. With thirty-five years of civil-servant experience under my belt, I was quite aware that the default relationship between a new boss and the organization that he comes into laterally is of distrust and suspicion. The new boss has to work hard early on in his tenure to tear down those barriers and establish his credentials to earn the respect of his staff. But here I was, forced to perform at peak level, under high-profile visibility even before the large majority of the senior staff of the Reserve Bank, let alone the thousands of subordinate staff, got to know me.